

**DIVIDED THEY STAND...** Leaders of the INDIA bloc

**The Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance, or INDIA, once heralded as the grand** anti-Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) coalition, now teeters at the edge of irrelevance. Its survival is hanging by the thinnest of threads as internal contradictions, personal ambitions and regional rivalries chip away at its foundation. What began as an urgent alliance of necessity to counter the BJP in the 2024 Lok Sabha election now resembles a house divided. The recent electoral drubbing in Delhi, coupled with reverses in Maharashtra and Haryana last year, has only underscored the alliance's vulnerabilities—an uneasy mix of ideological divergences, historical baggage and an utter lack of coordination, all conspiring to weaken what was touted as a formidable national alternative.

From the outset, the alliance was built on contradictions. The Congress, the largest constituent, has failed to reconcile its past dominance with the necessity of ceding space to regional outfits like the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), the Trinamool Congress (TMC) and the Samajwadi Party (SP). While they put up a surprisingly strong fight in the 2024 general election, denting the BJP's absolute majority, the cracks in their unity have since widened. The Delhi assembly polls exposed these fault lines in brutal fashion—the AAP and Congress contested separately, their mutual hostility palpable, their losses predictable. The BJP marched back to power in the capital after 27 years, an outcome that could have been avoided had the Opposition acted with a modicum of strategic foresight.

In Maharashtra, too, the Opposition failed to present a unified front against the BJP-Shiv Sena-Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) government. In Haryana, the Congress-AAP failed its first test of unity; that presaged the BJP victory. Each failure adds to the growing disillusionment within the bloc, reinforcing the idea that the alliance is little more than a tactical convenience, crumbling the moment realpolitik takes precedence over collective ambition.

With AAP's defeat in Delhi, the count of non-BJP, non-NDA (National Democratic Alliance) states has shrunk to just nine—West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Punjab, Karnataka, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Telangana, and Jammu & Kashmir. The alliance, initially envisioned as a national force, now seems reduced to a cluster of regional power centres, each protecting its own turf with little interest in sustained cooperation. Bihar, where the Congress, Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and the Left are technically in an alliance, looms as a dicey laboratory ahead of year-end polls. If recent trends hold, the likelihood of pre-election wrangling and post-election backstabbing looks higher than any collective cheer.

Now, either the alliance must iron out internal differences, prioritise electoral pragmatism over personal ego and present a coherent alternative, or continue on its current trajectory, lurching from one disaster to another. The people of India want it to follow the first path. That's the reason, despite persistent scepticism from political observers and detractors about INDIA's longevity, the electorate appears to be signalling a strong preference for its continuation.

**75%**

**of ST respondents want INDIA bloc to continue, highest among all the caste groups while 32 per cent of privileged caste respondents want it to end, the highest among all caste groups**

The latest Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll, conducted in February 2025, reaffirms this sentiment, with 65 per cent of the respondents expressing their support for the bloc's continuation. This finding reasserts the fact that the voters do not merely want the Opposition forces to engage in symbolic or superficial exercises but expect them to play a constructive role in strengthening democracy and holding the incumbent government—increasingly perceived as authoritarian—accountable on matters of public welfare and economic progress. Whenever the Opposition parties have presented a unified and coherent stance on